‘Shane, good to see you again.’ And his reply was, ‘Hersch, it’s always good to be seen.’ Never short of a sharp comeback is Warnie.

As tough as it was to have him as an opponent, it was also a privilege to face him – I’m proud to have played against the best spinner ever. I feel sorry for the next generation. They won’t have the privilege of playing against a spinner of Warnie’s ilk … there is only ever going to be one Shane Keith Warne.

Muttiah Muralitharan

Murali … I still can’t read him after 14 years of playing against the guy. I got two 90s playing against Murali, and I can honestly say I never read one goddamn ball. Look, he wasn’t effective at all in South Africa, as the ball never turns much here, so it was fine. Here, you could play him quite easily. But face him on the subcontinent, in Sri Lanka, where they prepare wickets specifically for him, and it’s a completely different proposition. That’s why his home-and-away record is so different.

It kind of annoys me that I’ve never scored a century in Sri Lanka, but I’ve only got myself to blame, really. I know Jacques Kallis shares a similar frustration. He’s scored 35 Test centuries and still hasn’t got one against Sri Lanka either, though he does have one ODI 100 scored in Colombo in 2004. But he can read Murali … or so he says.

My strategy was basically just to sweep the living kak out of him. That way, playing the ball on length, even if he spins it away from a right-hand batsman, you can still cover the spin. And if he spins it into you, then you sweep with the spin. Either way, you’re smothering his spin. So, if you are going to do that with every second ball he bowls to you, and execute it very well, he’s going to start dropping it a little bit shorter, and then you can play him off the back foot. Your default is to play the ball that’s spinning into you and, if you see it coming fairly straight, then you know it’s going to be the one that turns the other way.

To execute the sweep effectively, you’ve got to get your front pad in line with the ball so that, if you miss it, at least you don’t get bowled. A lot of players don’t execute the sweep correctly – the arc of their sweep is horizontal to the ground, which means that they don’t cover the spin. The chances of getting a top edge then are high. And, remember, Murali also bowls fairly quickly for a spinner. What you have to do is sweep in an arc from high to low. In other words, you sweep down, and in that way you